THE BUTLER'S ACCOMPANIMENT BOOK

A tune and three chords

Give me a melody and three chords, and I will make it sound lovely. This book teaches the left hand (and later both hands) to accompany any simple tune: first find the chords, then give them a pattern, then make them move.

Every lesson

1

See it

One picture shows the new pattern.

2

Work it out

Examples ask; you answer, then check the result line.

3

Play it on a tune

A tune everyone knows, in its simplest form.

The levels

LEVEL	TITLE	WHAT YOU LEARN	LESSONS
1	Find the chord	I, IV and V; chord symbols; three keys	1–3
2	The left hand joins in	root, 5th, whole cake; steady patterns; changes on time	4–6
3	Make it move	broken chords, the waltz, Alberti bass	7–9
4	Smooth hands	inversions; the shared note stays	later
5	Colours	sus, add9, 6, maj7	later
6	Style patterns	ballad, pop, march, bossa nova, stride	later
7	Reharmonise	new chords for an old tune	later
8	Lead sheets	intros, endings, accompanying a singer	later

Tunes in Levels 1–3: Mary Had a Little Lamb, Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star, Ode to Joy, Au clair de la lune, Amazing Grace, and Mozart's Sonata in C. All are free to play and share.

You need to read notes in both clefs and know what a chord is: the Handbook explains chords (p. 107), chords in a key (p. 113) and chords under a melody (p. 139).

HOW TO

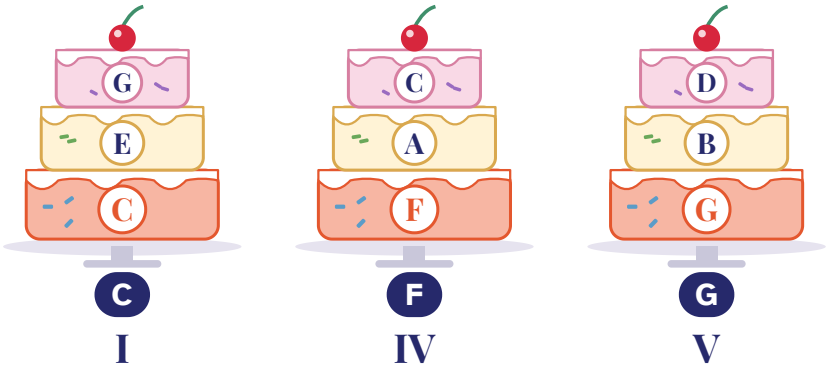
How to practise a lesson

1. **Hands separately:** the tune alone, then the left hand alone, counting aloud.
2. **Together, slowly:** the tune sings, the left hand stays softer.
3. **Make it yours:** try the pattern on another tune you know.

LESSON 1

Find the chord

Most simple tunes need only **three chords**. Count up the scale of C: C is note 1, F note 4, G note 5, so we call their chords **I**, **IV** and **V**. Your job is to choose one for each bar; the tune tells you which.
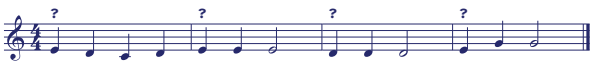


The three cakes of C major

THE RULE

Main notes are the ones on beats 1 and 3, and the long ones. Find the cake that holds them. If two cakes fit, let your ear choose.

EXAMPLE 1

Choose a chord for each bar



?

1. **Bar 1:** the main notes are E and C. Which cake holds both?
2. **Bar 3:** D D D. Which cake has a D in it?
3. **Bars 2 and 4:** E E E, then E G G.

Bars 1, 2 and 4 take **C** (C E G); bar 3 takes **G** (G B D).

GAME

Which cake holds the bar?

1	2	3	4
E D C D	D D D	G G G	F A F A
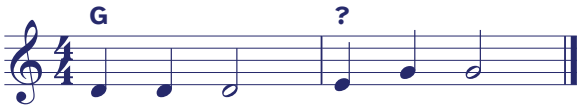
All in C major. Pick I (C), IV (F) or V (G) for each bar.

Answer: 1 C · 2 G · 3 C or G (G is in both: let your ear choose) · 4 F.

LESSON 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

When two cakes fit





?

1 **Bar 4 leans on G.** Which cakes have a G in them?

2 **Look at its other notes:** E. Which of the two cakes has an E?

3 **Listen:** which sounds like coming home?

G is in both cakes, but E is only in C: **C**, and it sounds like home after the G of bar 3.

GAME

Your turn: Twinkle

1	2
C C G G	A A G
3	4
F F E E	D D C

Twinkle in C major. Choose I, IV or V for each half bar.

Answer: 1 C · 2 F, then C · 3 F, then C · 4 G, then C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
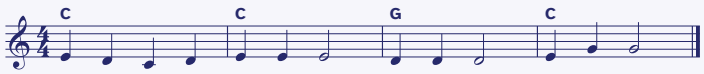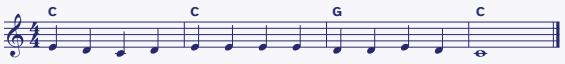


Find D in the cakes.

D is only in the G cake. B too. So whenever a bar leans on D or B, G is your chord.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb, with its chords





Only **two chords**, C and G, carry the whole tune. The chord names sit **above** the first note of each bar.

Try it. Play the tune and say the chord name at each bar.

MAKE IT YOURS

Choose chords for Au clair de la lune: C C C D | E (2) D (2) | C E D D | C (4). Write one chord per bar, or two where the bar changes, then play it.
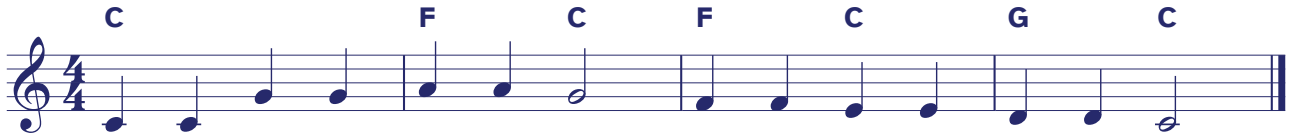
TRAP

× Choosing a chord for every note: one chord per bar (sometimes two) is plenty; the short notes between don't need to belong to it.

LESSON 2

Read the chord symbols

Songbooks write the chords as letters above the tune: **chord symbols**. A letter alone is a major chord; a small **m** makes it minor; a **7** adds one more layer. Each symbol lasts until the next one.



Letters above the tune: the chords
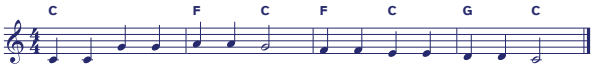
SYMBOL	SAY IT	NOTES (PLAY ONE, SKIP ONE)
C	C major	C E G
Am	A minor (small m)	A C E
G7	G seventh: one more layer	G B D F
F	F major	F A C

THE RULE

A symbol holds until the next symbol. No new symbol at a bar line: keep the same chord.

EXAMPLE 1

How long does each chord last?
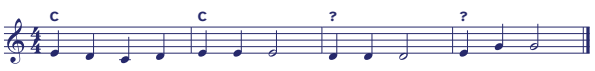


?

1. **Bar 1:** one symbol. How many beats?
2. **Bars 2–4:** two symbols in each bar. Where does the second one sit?
3. **So** how many beats for each?

C for the whole of bar 1 (4 beats); after that every chord lasts **2 beats**: F C, F C, G C.

EXAMPLE 3

What comes after the G?



?

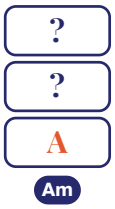
1. **Bar 3** says G. Which notes does the tune use?
2. **Bar 4** has a ? Its main notes are E and G.
3. **Which cake** holds E and G?

Bar 3 is G (D D D); bar 4 goes home to **C**: C E G holds both E and G.

LESSON 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Spell Am



1. **Start on A**, the bottom layer.
2. **Skip one letter**, take the next. Then again.
3. **The small m**: major or minor?

A C E: the A minor chord. On white keys, the cakes on C, F and G are major; on D, E and A they are minor. The symbol tells you which.

GAME

Spell the chord

1	2
G	Dm
3	4
F	Em

Write the three notes of each chord.

Answer: 1 G B D · 2 D F A · 3 F A C · 4 E G B.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

C · Am · G7 · F

Play the four symbols.

Play each chord as a whole cake, right hand: C, Am, G7, F. Say its name as you play it.

MAKE IT YOURS

Write the chord symbols above Mary Had a Little Lamb from memory (one per bar), then check them on page 2 and play them as whole cakes, right hand.

THINK OF IT Chord symbols are a shopping list: they say what to buy, not how to cook it. How you play them is your recipe, and the next lessons are the cookbook.

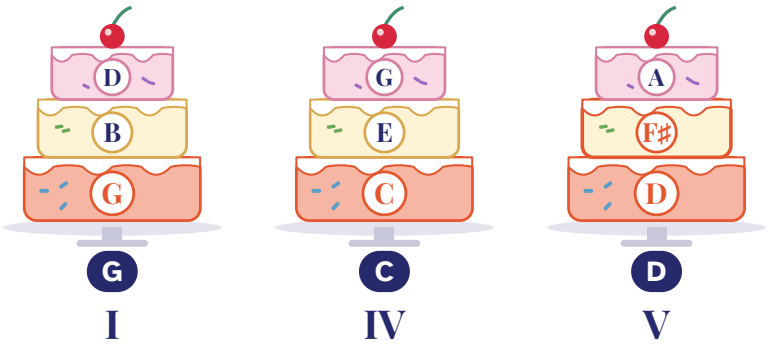
TRAP

- × Reading Am as A major: the small m means minor.
- × Changing chord at every bar line: a symbol lasts until the next one.
- × Playing G7 as plain G: the 7 adds one more layer, F, on top.
- × Playing every symbol as a loud block: the chords are the band, the tune is the singer.

LESSON 3

Three chords in G and F

Every major key has its own I, IV and V. In G major they are G, C and D; in F major F, B♭ and C. Find them the same way: from the home note, count up to the 4th and the 5th.



The three cakes of G major
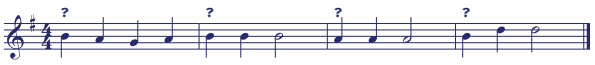
KEY	I	IV	V
C major	C E G	F A C	G B D
G major	G B D	C E G	D F♯ A
F major	F A C	B♭ D F	C E G

THE RULE

I is the home note, IV the 4th note up, V the 5th. Keep the key's sharp or flat: the D chord in G major has F♯; the B♭ chord in F major has B♭.

EXAMPLE 1

Mary in G major
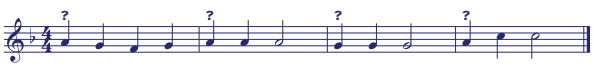


?

1. **The key:** one sharp, G major. Its cakes are G, C, D.
2. **Bars 1 and 2** lean on B and G; **bar 4** on B and D. Which cake?
3. **Bar 3:** A A A. Which cake has an A?

G G D G: the same plan as in C (I I V I), moved to G.

EXAMPLE 2

Mary in F major



?

1. **The key:** one flat, F major. Its cakes are F, B♭, C.
2. **Bars 1 and 2** lean on A and F; **bar 4** on A and C.
3. **Bar 3:** G G G. Which cake has a G?

F F C F: again I I V I.

LESSON 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Which key?

G · C · F | D · G · C | C · F · B♭ ?

1. **Each group** is one key's I, IV and V.
2. **Find the chord** whose 4th and 5th are the other two: that is I.
3. **Name** each key.

C major (C F G), **G major** (G C D), **F major** (F B♭ C): I names the key.

HOW TO

Find I, IV and V in any major key

1. **I:** the key's home note (the key's name).
2. **IV and V:** count up its scale to the 4th and 5th notes.
3. **Build each cake** with the key's sharps or flats.

GAME

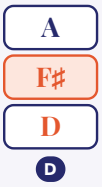
I, IV or V?

1. V in G
2. IV in F
3. IV in C
4. IV in G

Name the chord.

Answer: 1 D · 2 B♭ · 3 F · 4 C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



I IV V I in G.

Right hand, whole cakes: G, C, D, G. Do you hear the F♯ in D?

TWO-MINUTE DRILL I IV V I in each key, whole cakes in the right hand: C F G C · G C D G · F B♭ C F.

MAKE IT YOURS

Play Mary in all three keys, C, G and F, and say the chord names aloud as you play the tune. Which key suits your voice best for singing along?

THINK OF IT A new key is a new house: the rooms are in the same places (I, IV, V); only the address changes.

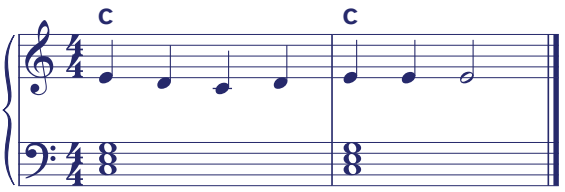
TRAP

- × Forgetting the F♯ in the D chord (key of G).
- × Forgetting the B♭ in the B♭ chord (key of F).
- × Reading the key signature once and then forgetting it: it holds for the whole piece.

LESSON 4
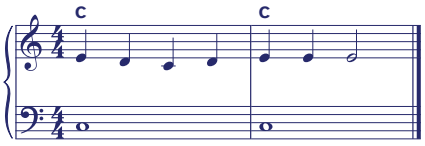
Your left hand joins in

Now the left hand plays the chord you chose. Start tiny: one note. When it feels easy, add a note. Then the whole cake. Same chord, three sizes.

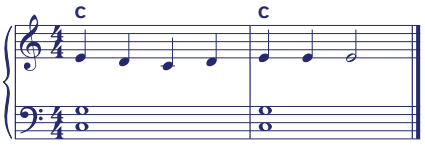


Same chord, three sizes

STEP	THE LEFT HAND PLAYS	SOUNDS	GOOD FOR
1	the bottom layer, called the **root**	light, simple	lullabies, first tries
2	root and top layer (C and G)	strong, open	marches, folk songs
3	the whole cake	full, warm	hymns, ballads, the last chord



Step 1: the root.
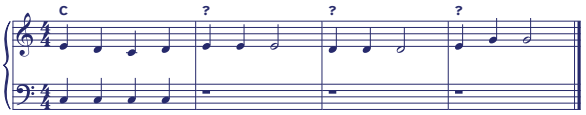


Step 2: root and top.

THE RULE

Pick the step that feels easy, play the tune with it, then move up one step. Nobody hears which step you use; everybody hears whether it is steady.

EXAMPLE 1

Make it pulse



1. **Choose the chords** for bars 2–4 (Lesson 1).
2. **Bar 1** plays the root on every beat. Fill in bars 2–4 the same way.
3. **How many notes** in each bar?

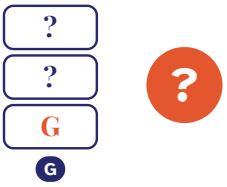
C, G, C: **C C C C · G G G G · C C C C**, four roots in every bar.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Left hand alone, step 1 then step 3: C for four beats, G for four beats, C for four beats. Ten times, steady.

LESSON 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Step 2 on G



1. **Build the G cake:** skip one, take the next.
2. **Step 2** keeps only two layers. Which two?
3. **Play them** low in the left hand.

The root and the top layer: **G and D**.

HOW TO

Practise it in three rounds

1. **Round 1:** left hand alone, step 1, counting 1 2 3 4.
2. **Round 2:** right hand tune with left hand step 1.
3. **Round 3:** the same with step 2, then step 3.

GAME

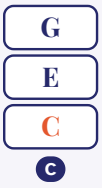
Which step?

1	2	3
a lullaby	a march	a hymn

Choose step 1, 2 or 3 for each.

Answer: 1 step 1 · 2 step 2 · 3 step 3 (any step can work: these are the usual choices).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hold C, sing Mary.

Left hand holds C E G while you sing the first two bars. Then G B D for bar 3. You are accompanying!

MAKE IT YOURS

Accompany a song you know: first with step 1, then step 3. Which step makes it sound fullest?

THINK OF IT A band starts small: first the drummer, then the bass, then the whole band. Your left hand is all three, one step at a time.

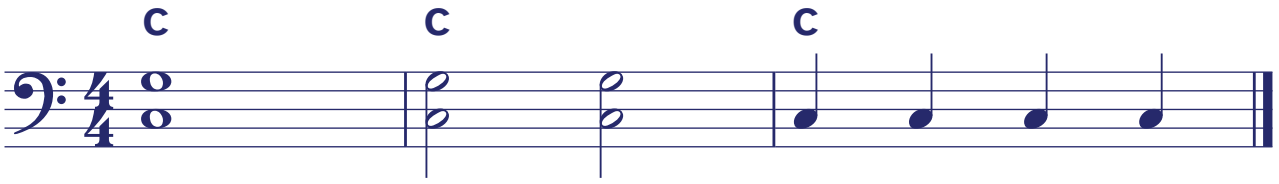
TRAP

- × Rushing at the chord change: the new chord lands on beat 1, not before.
- × Playing the left hand as loud as the tune: the tune is the singer, the left hand the band.

LESSON 5

Keep the beat

The left hand is the band's drummer. Once the chords are right, give them a steady pattern: one long note, then two, then four. The tune stays the same; the feeling changes.



Semibreve, minims, crotchets: the band speeds up
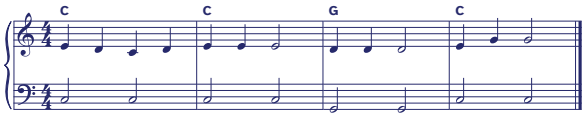
PATTERN	THE LEFT HAND PLAYS	FEELS LIKE
whole bar	one long note or chord	calm, slow songs
two per bar	on beats 1 and 3	walking songs
four per bar	every beat	marches, bright songs
root and 5th	C G C G (bottom and top layers)	country, folk, a bouncy bass

THE RULE

Choose one pattern for a whole verse. Change it only at a new section. Before the tune starts, play one bar of your pattern on chord I: the singer hears the speed and the key.

EXAMPLE 1

Count the left hand
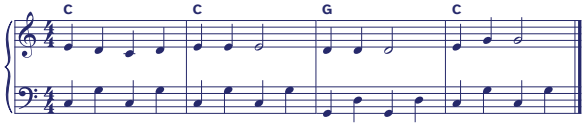


?

1. **Count 1 2 3 4** in each bar.
2. **The left hand** plays on which counts?
3. **How many notes** in each bar?

Two minims in each bar, on **1 and 3**: a walking feel.

EXAMPLE 2

Root and 5th



?

1. **Bars 1, 2, 4:** which two notes take turns?
2. **Bar 3** (G): which two?
3. **Which layers** of the cake are they?

C and G, then **G and D**: the bottom and top layers of each cake, taking turns.

LESSON 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Which pattern fits?

a lullaby · a march · a folk dance ?

1. **A lullaby** rocks gently: long or short notes?
2. **A march** steps on every beat.
3. **A folk dance** bounces.

Lullaby: **whole bar** · march: **four per bar** · folk dance: **root and 5th**.

HOW TO

Practise a pattern

1. **Left hand alone**, counting aloud, until the pattern runs by itself.
2. **Add the tune** slowly; the left hand never stops.
3. **Try the same pattern** on another tune you know.

GAME

How many left-hand notes?

1. whole bar, 4 bars
2. two per bar, 4 bars
3. four per bar, 2 bars
4. root and 5th, 2 bars

Count the left-hand notes.

Answer: 1 4 · 2 8 · 3 8 · 4 8.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

C G C G · G D G D

Mary with a bounce.

Play Mary with root and 5th: C G C G, and G D G D in bar 3. Keep the left hand lighter than the tune.

MAKE IT YOURS

Play Twinkle four ways: whole bar, two per bar, four per bar, root and 5th. Choose the one you like best and write it above the music.

THINK OF IT The same song can wear slippers, walking shoes or dancing shoes. The left-hand pattern is the shoes.

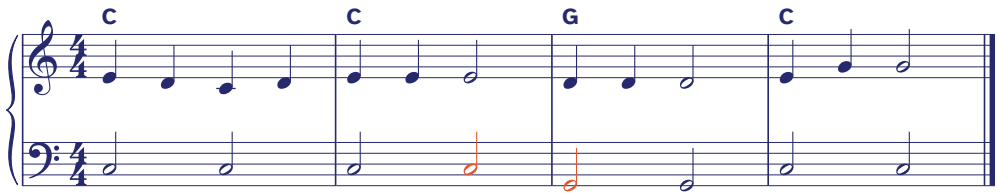
TRAP

- × Speeding up when the left hand gets busy: a metronome helps.
- × Changing pattern in the middle of a line: wait for a new section.

LESSON 6

Changing chords on time

The hardest moment is the change. The left hand must land on the new chord exactly on beat 1. The trick: look one bar ahead, and move during the last beat.

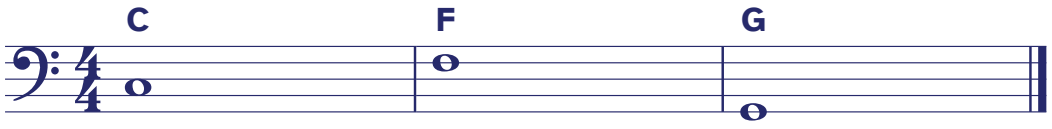


Let go during beat 4 of bar 2; land on G on beat 1 of bar 3.

Move on beat 4, land on beat 1

Plan the move

Every new root can be reached two ways: up or down. Choose the nearer one, so the hand barely moves. From G to C, for example: up is G A B C (three steps), down is G F E D C (four). Go **up**.
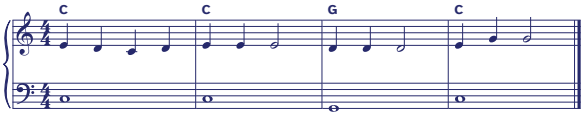


Three roots, three small moves.

THE RULE

Look one bar ahead. Move on beat 4, land on beat 1. A late chord is heard; a plain one is not.

EXAMPLE 1

When do you move?



?

1. **Find the change:** C to G, between which bars?
2. **On which beat** do you start to move?
3. **On which beat** must you land?

During **beat 4 of bar 2** move, and land on G on beat 1 of bar 3.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Left hand roots only: C F C G C, saying the next chord aloud on every beat 4. Ten times without a stop.

LESSON 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Up or down to G?

from C: G above or G below? ?

1. **Up:** C D E F G, how many steps?
2. **Down:** C B A G, how many?
3. **Choose** the smaller move.

Down: three steps (C B A G) beats four steps up.

EXAMPLE 3

Plan F, then G

C → F → G ?

1. **C to F:** up or down is nearer?
2. **F to G:** one step up, or a long way down?
3. **Play** the plan.

C, **up** to F, then **up one step** to G: the hand walks, it never jumps.

GAME

Up or down?

1. C → F
2. C → G
3. F → G
4. G (below) → C

Choose the nearer move for the root.

Answer: 1 up · 2 down · 3 up · 4 up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

C → F → C → G → C

Eyes ahead.

Play Mary with roots. On every beat 4, say the next chord's name aloud, then move.

HOW TO

Practise the change

1. **Left hand alone:** play each root for four beats, moving on beat 4.
2. **Add the tune** slowly; keep the left hand landing on beat 1.
3. **Speed up** only when every change is on time.

MAKE IT YOURS

Make a change map for Twinkle: write each chord change, the beat you move on, and up or down. Then try G7 instead of G in bar 7 of Mary: one more layer, the same root.

THINK OF IT Like stepping onto an escalator: you lift your foot before the step arrives.

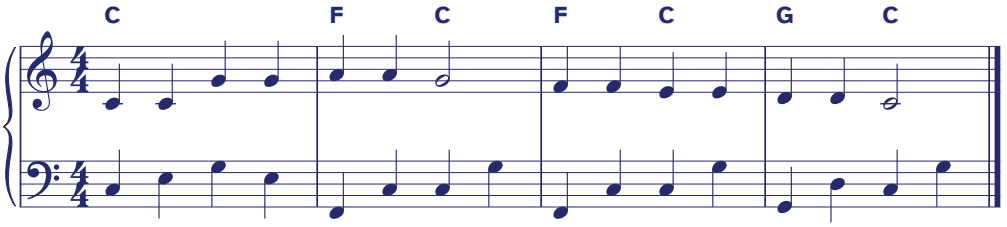
TRAP

- × Moving on beat 1: the chord arrives late.
- × Looking at the left hand: keep your eyes on the music, one bar ahead.
- × Jumping a long way for every chord: choose the nearer root, up or down.

LESSON 7

Broken chords
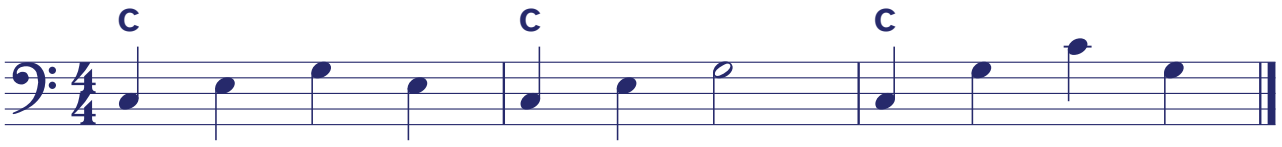
A broken chord plays the cake one layer at a time instead of all at once. The tune keeps singing; the left hand ripples underneath.



A whole bar: bottom, middle, top, middle. Half a bar: two notes each, bottom and top.

Bottom, middle, top, middle

PATTERN	ON C	FEELS LIKE
up and back	C E G E	flowing, gentle
up and hold	C E G (held)	calm, open
spread	C G C G (wide)	a big, warm sound



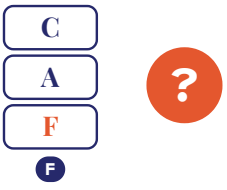
Up and back, up and hold, spread.

THE RULE

Keep the bottom note a little stronger: it names the chord. The other layers stay soft and even.

EXAMPLE 1

Spell it broken



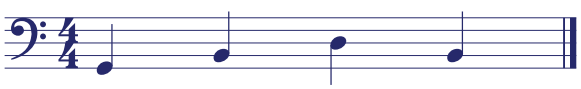
1. **Bottom, middle, top**: name them.
2. **Then back** to the middle.
3. **Write** the four notes.

F A C A: up and back.

LESSON 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which chord is broken here?
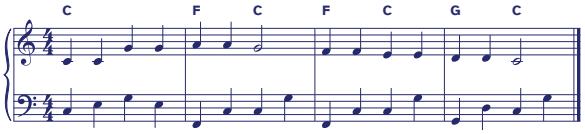


?

1. **Read the notes** in the bass clef.
2. **Stack them**: bottom, middle, top.
3. **Which cake** is it?

G B D B: the **G chord**, broken up and back.

EXAMPLE 3

Half a bar each



?

1. **Bar 2** has two chords, F then C.
2. **How many beats** for each?
3. **So** how many notes of each broken chord?

Two beats each: **F C**, then **C G**, the bottom and top of each cake.

GAME

Break these

1	2
C	G
3	4
Am	F

Write each chord up and back.

Answer: 1 C E G E · 2 G B D B · 3 A C E C · 4 F A C A.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

C E G E

Ripple and sing.

Play Twinkle with broken chords, up and back, while you hum the tune. Then add the right hand.

MAKE IT YOURS

Invent your own broken pattern, for example bottom, top, middle, top, and play Mary with it. Give your pattern a name.

THINK OF IT A broken chord is a cake served slice by slice: the same cake, just easier to enjoy.

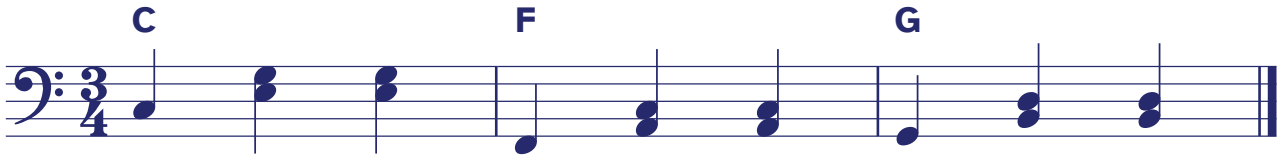
TRAP

- × Every note the same loudness: lean a little on the bottom note.
- × Rushing the ripple: four even notes, one on each beat.

LESSON 8

The waltz

In 3/4 the left hand dances: **oom-pah-pah**. The bottom layer on beat 1, the top two layers together on beats 2 and 3.



Oom on 1, pah pah on 2 and 3

CHORD	OOM (BEAT 1)	PAH PAH (BEATS 2, 3)
C	C	E G
F	F	A C
G	G	B D

THE RULE
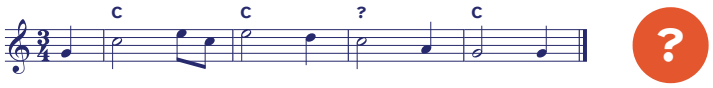
Upbeat: a tune may start before beat 1, like "A-" in Amazing Grace. No chord yet: the left hand waits and comes in on beat 1 of the first full bar.

THE RULE

Beat 1 low and a little stronger; beats 2 and 3 light and short, like a skip.

EXAMPLE 1

Find the missing chord



1. **Amazing Grace** in C major, 3/4. It starts on an upbeat: no chord yet.
2. **The bar with ?** leans on C and A.
3. **Which cake** holds C and A?

F (F A C): "sweet the". Then home to C.

EXAMPLE 3

Oom-pah or oom-pah-pah?

2/4 3/4 4/4 ?

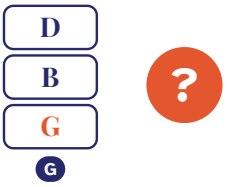
1. **Count** the beats in each bar.
2. **Oom** always takes beat 1.
3. **How many pahs** follow?

2/4: oom-pah · 3/4: **oom-pah-pah** · 4/4: oom-pah-oom-pah.

LESSON 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Write the oom-pah-pah



1 **Oom:** the bottom layer.

2 **Pah pah:** the other two layers, together.

3 **Write** beat by beat.

G · B D · B D.

GAME

Waltz it

1	2
C	F
3	4
G	Am

Write oom · pah pah for each chord.

Answer: 1 C · E G · 2 F · A C · 3 G · B D · 4 A · C E.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

oom · pah · pah
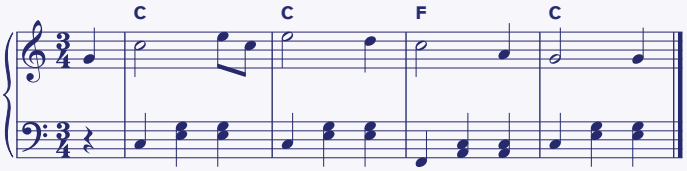
Dance first.

Say "oom-pah-pah" and step on "oom". Then play C, F, G, C with the left hand only.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Oom-pah-pah on C, F, G, C, two bars each, with a metronome at a slow speed. Keep the pahs light.

YOU KNOW THIS

Amazing Grace, with its waltz



The left hand waits through the upbeat, then dances **oom-pah-pah** on C, C, F, C.

Try it. Sing the words while your left hand plays.

MAKE IT YOURS

Play Amazing Grace with oom-pah-pah, then end with a rolled C chord: play C E G from the bottom up, quickly, and hold it.

THINK OF IT A waltz is a dancer: one big step, two little ones, round and round.

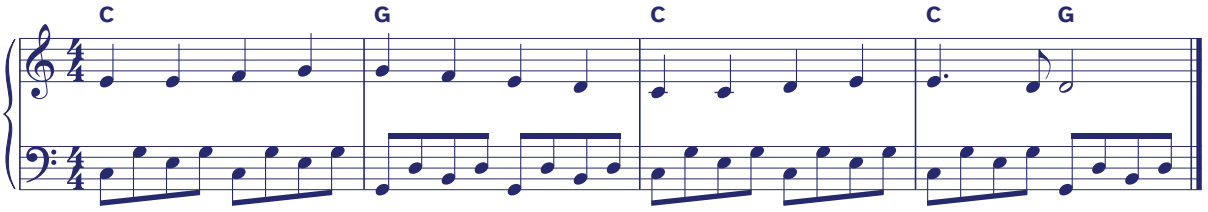
TRAP

- × A heavy pah: beats 2 and 3 are lighter than beat 1.
- × Rushing the change: the new oom lands on beat 1.

LESSON 9
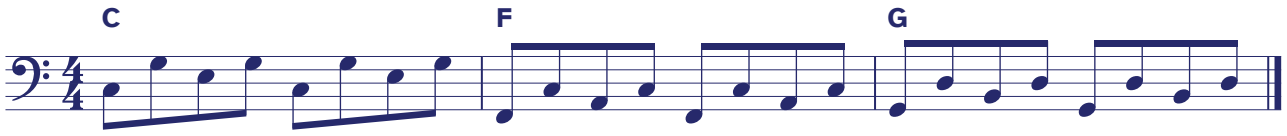
Alberti bass

Low, high, middle, high: the **Alberti bass** keeps quavers rocking under a slow tune. Mozart loved it, and it makes the plainest melody sound elegant.



Low, high, middle, high

CHORD	ALBERTI (TWO BEATS)	THE ORDER
C	C G E G	bottom, top, middle, top
F	F C A C	bottom, top, middle, top
G	G D B D	bottom, top, middle, top



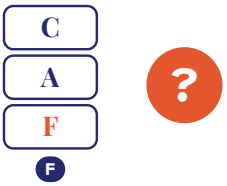
C, F and G as Alberti bass.

THE RULE

Keep the quavers even and soft; let only the bottom note lean a little. The tune always sings louder.

EXAMPLE 1

Write it for F



1. **Bottom**, then **top**.
2. **Middle**, then **top** again.
3. **Write** the four notes.
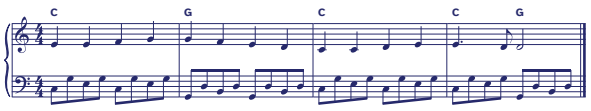
F C A C.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Alberti on C, F, G, C, one bar each, slowly and evenly. Then twice as fast, still soft.

LESSON 9 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Count the rocks



?

1. **Count the quavers** in bar 1.
2. **One rock** is four quavers.
3. **How many rocks** in a bar?

Eight quavers: **two rocks** per bar of 4/4.

GAME

Rock these

1	2
C	G
3	4
Am	F

Write each chord as an Alberti bass.

Answer: 1 C G E G · 2 G D B D · 3 A E C E · 4 F C A C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
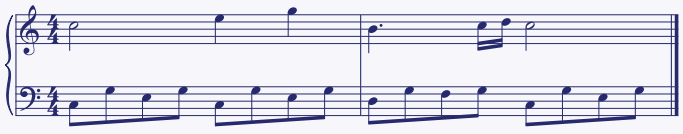
C G E G

Slow rocks first.

Play C G E G slowly, four times, with a steady pulse. Then F C A C, G D B D. Then put Ode to Joy on top.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545



The right hand sings; the left hand rocks **C G E G**, then D G F G (a G7 chord, its notes rearranged): the most famous Alberti bass of all.

Try it. Play the left hand alone, softly and evenly.

MAKE IT YOURS

Play Twinkle with an Alberti bass in C, then in G (G D B D, C G E G, D A F♯ A).

THINK OF IT An Alberti bass is a rocking chair: steady, gentle, never in a hurry. If the chair speeds up, the tune can't settle.

TRAP

- × Loud quavers: the Alberti bass whispers.
- × Uneven rocks: practise with a metronome, slowly.
- × Using it for a fast, busy tune: Alberti suits slow, singing melodies.